



BLACK WIDOW

NATALIA ALIANOVNA ROMANOVA is an orphan who was found and raised by a Russian soldier, who would one day become her chauffeur. In her teens, Natasha, as friends called her, proved to be a brilliant scholar and a gifted athlete and ballet dancer. She later married a renowned Soviet test pilot. After her husband was reported killed, Natasha honored his memory by joining the KGB and training as a spy.

THE SECRET AGENT

The Black Widow never trained to be a costumed agent. She was only supposed to be a spy. Her first major mission was to help assassinate an employee of Stark Industries, but Iron Man stopped her. She soon met Hawkeye, who quickly fell in love with her. On the run from the police, Hawkeye willingly teamed-up with her against Iron Man. However, Natasha gradually grew disillusioned with her Soviet masters. She decided to defect to the West, but was seriously wounded.



Agent of S.H.I.E.L.D

After a brief reunion with Hawkeye, the Widow offered her services to Nick Fury and S.H.I.E.L.D. She performed numerous missions for this worldwide intelligence and peacekeeping organization.

Called to Assemble

After helping the Avengers battle Magneto and the Lion-God, the Black Widow led a super-team called the Champions, who helped the Avengers rescue Hercules from the giant immortal Typhon. After the Champions disbanded, the Widow was invited to join the Avengers. On her first mission, she faced the

Tetrarchs of Entropy, powerful alien caretakers of a dimension full of evils and super-prisoners.

WIDOW'S BITE

The Widow carries various grenades, a cable line, and a wrist-blaster she calls her "Widow's Bite."



HAWKEYE HOOKED

The Black Widow couldn't allow herself to return Hawkeye's love.

The Widow is a master of many martial arts.

SWORDSMAN

JACQUES DUQUESNE grew up admiring a relative known as the Crimson Cavalier, a costumed hero who fought against the Nazis. When he heard that the country of Sin-Cong was fighting for independence, Jacques became the Swordsman and joined the revolutionaries. He later renounced political activism and chose to become a mercenary.



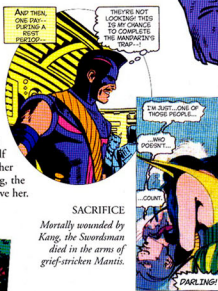
The Swordsman is a master of throwing knives and other bladed weapons, and skilled in unarmed combat.

UNREPENTANT

Jacques performed in a circus, befriending young Clint Barton. When Jacques robbed the circus payroll Clint turned against him, and the Swordsman fled to Europe becoming a notorious criminal. He then offered his services to the Avengers, hoping to use them to commit even greater crimes.

A Hero's Death

The Avengers turned down the Swordsman, who joined the Mandarin and attempted to destroy them. However, he grew to admire the team—especially the Scarlet Witch and Mantis, with whom he fell in love. She refused to date a criminal so he turned his life around. Now a champion for justice, the Swordsman begged the Avengers for a second chance. He proved himself a valuable ally, but Mantis still kept her distance. Battling the tyrant Kang, the Swordsman gave his life to save her.

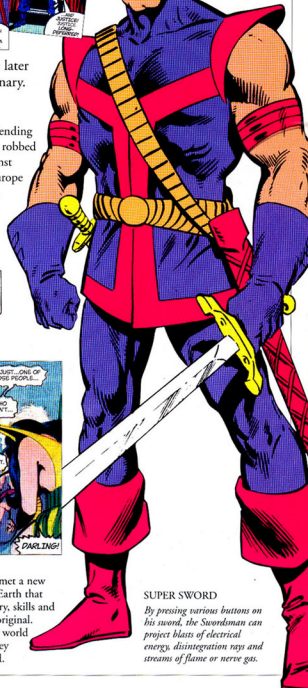


SACRIFICE

Mortally wounded by Kang, the Swordsman died in the arms of grief-stricken Mantis.

The Second Swordsman

A few years later, the Avengers met a new Swordsman, from an alternate Earth that had been destroyed. His life story, skills and personality are identical to the original. The new Swordsman travels the world with Magdalene (see p.112). They aid the Avengers whenever called.



SUPER SWORD

By pressing various buttons on his sword, the Swordsman can project blasts of electrical energy, disintegration rays and streams of flame or nerve gas.

